Fangs of Endearment

By Dave Barry

BELLA: With a feeling of ominous foreboding, I turned my battered old pickup truck into the last remaining parking spot outside Creepstone High School. I glanced in the rearview mirror and scrunched my forehead in dismay as I realized for the millionth time that I do not consider myself at all attractive, although roughly 85 percent of the male characters I encounter either fall in love with me or want to kill me, or both, and in the movie version I am portrayed by a total babe.

INTRODUCTION

Twilight . . . Who doesn't love a good vampire vs werewolf saga, right? As proof, Stephenie Meyer's Twilight series has sold over 100 million copies. But the question is . . . why? I apologize in advance to Team Edward and Team Jacob, but let's face it . . . the writing is . . . ***bad****, laughably bad.*

Have you ever heard of "purple prose" – It consists of words and phrases that sound stilted, overly descriptive or cliché. No? Let me show you what I mean. This is Dave Barry's Fangs of Endearment - a humorous tribute to the writing style of Stephenie Meyer. . adjectives and adverbs and similes, Oh, my!

Chapter 1: Warning

BELLA: Heaving a sigh of exasperation, I creaked open the truck door, and with my trademark charming clumsiness, fell out face-first. But before I hit the asphalt, Phil [aka Team Edward] was there to catch me, having covered the 75 yards from his luxury car to my truck in 2/10ths of a second. Fortunately nobody noticed this because Phil is brilliantly clever, and the other students at Creepstone High have the observational skills of boiled ham.

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Phil swooped me into his arms using the super vampire strength that he has in addition to his super vampire speed and his ability to read minds, perform complex mathematical calculations in his head, assemble a working nuclear submarine entirely from clock p arts, and recite all the lyrics to Guys and Dolls . . . backward.

Phil, a gorgeous brilliant wealthy sophisticated centuries-old vampire posing as a high-school student for reasons that are never totally clear, gently set me down on the parking lot and took my hand in his strong and perfect hand. As we entered the school I felt Phil's grip tighten. Possibly fracturing my ring and index fingers. Looking up I saw the reason: Stewart [aka Team Jacob] was striding toward us in an ominous way. Stewart is a member of an indigenous tribe of Native Americans who become werewolves at puberty, in addition to developing acne. They do not get along with the vampires. One time in Boys' phys. Ed. The two sides played each other in volleyball, and before it was over seven civilian students had been disemboweled. This could have created a real stink had not the Creepstone High authorities, who are even less observant than the student body, concluded that the cause was an unusually fast-acting stomach flu. *(to Stewart)* "Hello, Stewart" *(to audience)* He looked at Phil with a look of pure lanky indigenous hatred before turning to me and replying, with a voice drenched in the aching and smoldering longingness of a powerful emotion that I knew he could never express in words. *(to Stewart)* "What is it?"

He looked at me with his dark lanky eyes. Suddenly his expression changed to one of dark foreboding.

STEWART: *(whispering hoarsely)* If you go out in the woods today, you better not go alone.

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BELLA: *(to Stewart)* "What . . ." *(to audience)* I protested elliptically. But Stewart was already striding lankily away. Finally finding my voice, I inquired, *(to Phil)* "What did he mean by that?"

Phil turned his perfect gaze upon me, causing me to be struck by how unbelievably handsome he is, with his perfect face and chiseled cheekbones, and his gorgeous eyes that change color depending on how recently he has sucked all the blood out of a live bear, and his perfectly teased hair tousling down over his broad gorgeous forehead.

PHIL: I'm sure it's nothing. I'm especially sure it's not Denise the vengeful psychopathic female vampire from the previous book who has vowed to hunt you down and torture you to death and who has been sighted recently in the woods around Creepstone. There is definitely no need to worry about that.

BELLA: Despite Phil's reassurance, there was something in his tone that troubled me. But what was it? What had Stewart been trying to tell me? Was something bad about to happen? Would I soon find myself in yet another dramatic plot situation filled with peril? And why did everybody find me so attractive?

Chapter 2 – Decision

PETE: "How was school today?"

BELLA: inquired my father, Pete [aka Charlie]. Pete is chief of police of Creepstone, but he is not exactly Sherlock Holmes, if you catch my drift. He has so far failed to pick up on the fat that my boyfriend is a vampire who spends every night in my room, and that y other boyfriend is a werewolf, and that Creepstone, not to mention the entire state of Washington, is teeming with violent homicidal supernatural creatures, about 60 percent of whom are trying to kill me personally.

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(to Pete) "Fine." *(to audience)* Satisfied, Pete grunted and returned to his paper. Then remembering something in his mind, he looked up again.

PETE: By the way, I want you to stay out of the woods.

BELLA: *(with a gasp and air of foreboding)* Why?

PETE: In the past two days, 158 hikers have been killed in the woods around Creepstone.

BELLA: *(to Pete)* Killed? *(to audience)* I felt a cold feeling shoot through my veins like an intravenous Slushie. *(to Pete)* How?

PETE: It's the darnedest thing. All of them were violently dismembered, apparently by someone or something with incredibly savage strength. Some of the victim's limbs were found as far as two football fields away from their bodies.

BELLA: I stared at him with a facial expression of shock. *(to Pete)* "But how . . ." *(to audience)* I searched for the words to complete the question that was even then forming in my brain. *(to Pete)* "How did *two football fields* get into the woods?" *(to audience)* Pete shook his head and shrugged, raising and lowering his shoulders to indicate he didn't know the answer.

PETE: That's got us stumped so far. Right now we're working on the theory that it could be a bobcat, or a pack of unusually aggressive squirrels. But until we get this thing figured out, I don't want you going out in the woods, OK?

BELLA: My forehead puckered into a frown as I remembered that Phil has mentioned that Denise the psychopathic vampire had been sighted recently in the woods. Could she have something to do with the 158 slain hikers? Should I mention any of this to Pete? Nah. The more I thought about it, the more I knew what I had to do: ***I had to go out into the woods alone.*** That's what I always do with my trademark stubbornness: I place myself in grave plot peril when there is no coherent reason to do so. Some people may call this ridiculous, but I am guessing that "some people" have not sold [100] million books to date.

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I prepared to go out into the woods with nothing to protect me except my various attractive supernatural boyfriends. I did not know what peril I was about to face. All I knew was one thing, the most important thing of all: Whatever happened, it would involve me.

Chapter 3: Peril

BELLA: I stumbled through the woods, tripping with clumsy endearingness over the logs that lay everywhere, like the corpses of dead trees knocked down by gravity. It was getting dark, and I knew that Phil would be out looking for me with his tawny eyes nestled in the perfection of his face. Stewart would also be looking for me in his lanky way with his bulging, rippling muscles or giant snout, depending on what form he was in.

I came to a clearing completely surrounded on all sides by the dark forbidding words. I walked into the clearing as the cold wind blew my hair around into a big trademark mess, although fortunately I don't care about hair or makeup because the last thing I need to do is make myself even more irresistible. With a feeling of even greater foreboding than usual, I kept walking forward, putting one leg in front of the other in an alternating sequence.

Suddenly, I saw movement at the far edge of the clearing. I stopped and stared. A chill slithered up my spine like an ascending iguana wearing tiny booties made from pieces of Fudgsicle as I saw the terrifying shadowy figure step menacingly into the clearing. With a shock of recognition I recognized who it was: Denise. She bared her teeth, revealing her needle-like fangs, which glinted brightly in the moonlight like some kind of sharp highly reflective things used in a simile. I squinched my eyes shut, preparing myself to be killed in a horrible manner. The

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dramatic tension mounted to a fever pitch as I waited to feel Denise's teeth plunge vengefully into my neck and suck my blood out like a giant supernatural mosquito. I wondered how much it would hurt, and how long it would last before I was dead, and who, if anybody, would take over as narrator.

And just then it happened, a dramatic turn of events so unexpected and shocking that nobody could have predicted it in a million years without having read the previous books. I heard a snarling sound and opened my eyes to see that Denise, instead of attacking me, was fighting for her life. And the person she was fighting against – the person who, against all odds, had appeared at the last possible instant to rescue me, was: [Donald Trump] **the text says "Barbara Walters", but Donald Trump may be more fun and more relevant**

No, I am leavening the narrative with humor. It was really Phil. His eyes flashed me an alarmed look of tawny ominousness.

PHIL: *(urgently)* Run away; they're coming!

BELLA: He pointed toward the edge of the clearing. I looked in that direction, and my mouth gaped open as I saw them emerging from the woods: [Phil's] vampire family: Grover, Buck, Scooter, Eldrigede, DeeDee, Trixie and Skeeter. Grover nodded to Phil with a special code vampire nod, indicating something ominous was about to transpire.

PHIL: Stay here. Stay perfectly still. Whatever you do, ***don't do anything to draw attention to yourself***.

BELLA: An incredible battle had erupted between the werewolves and the various attractive sets of vampires. There were snarls and roars and hideous supernatural screams. It was incredibly exciting and terrifying, although because

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of my trademark inability to describe action in anything except very general terms you are just going to have to take my word for this.

As the battle raged on, an alarming thought crept into my mind: ***I was not playing a central role.*** I realized that I needed to do something. But what could I, a mere human, although a highly endearing one, do? Then it struck me: ***I could draw attention to myself***.

Frantically I looked around, searching for a sharp object. Suddenly I saw it, lying on the ground, clearly visible in the bright moonlight: A sharp object. I picked it up and stabbed at myself. Blood streamed redly down my leg. Suddenly there was a vampire stampede coming my way at the speed of vampire, with the werewolves right behind.

They were almost on me, dozens of blood-crazed vampires and enraged werewolves. I knew there was no way I could be saved. And then, at the absolute climactic height of the action sequence, everything went dark.

Chapter 4: Resolution

PHIL: She's coming around. . .

BELLA: *(to Phil)* What happened? *(to audience)* Phil shook his head lovingly.

PHIL: You almost got yourself and all of us killed because of your unbelievably irresponsible, deranged, and self-centered behavior, but that just makes me desire you more, you crazy, quirky, irresistible woman, you.

BELLA: But how did you win the climactic fight?

PHIL: Through a lot of action.

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BELLA: Wow. That must have been incredibly exciting. *(sighing in resignation)* Well, at least our other troubles are over. *(to audience)* Phil looked at me with an expression of not totally agreeing with my assertion. *(to Phil)* What is it? Is something wrong?

PHIL: It turns out that all those recent hiker deaths were not caused by Denise, but by a long-dormant supernatural race of giant homicidal pine cones who have been awakened by global warming and now prowl the woods around Creepstone each night, savagely attacking every living thing in their path!

BELLA: I thought that was just a Native American legend.

PHIL: If only. It's only a matter of time before they come into town and are attracted to you. And on top of all that, there's also the fact that Stewart and I are still mortal enemies who could very well kill each other in our relentless struggle to possess you.

BELLA: Until the next book . . . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
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